

TABLE 6.6 : POPULATION BY RACE AND RELIGION AND RELIGION AS A PERCENTAGE OF RACE - 1971.

Ethnic group	Number (in thousands)	Religion	Number (in thousands)	Religion as percentage of Ethnic Group
Sinhalese	9131.2	Buddhist	8536.9	93.5
Tamils	2598.6	Hindu	2238.9	86.1
Moors and Malays	899.1	Muslim	901.8	100.3
Burghers and Eurasians	45.3	Christian	1004.3	-

Unfortunately, a cross-classification of religious data, of the census of 1971, by ethnic group, is not available. However, the following table compiled by N.K. Sarkar from the Census Report of 1946,⁵ and the table above (6.6) give a rough idea of the racial characteristics of the religions in the Island.

TABLE 6.7 : RELIGION CLASSIFIED BY RACE

Religion	Low Country Sinhalese	Kandyan Sinhalese	Ceylon Tamils	Indian Tamils	Ceylon Moors	Indian Moors	Malays	Bur- ghers
Buddhists	87.90	98.77	2.61	2.27	1.00	0.02	2.35	2.77
Hindus	0.10	-	80.59	89.33	-	3.03	3.34	0.01
Muslims	0.01	-	-	-	98.67	95.23	92.02	0.01
Christians	11.90	1.03	16.54	8.09	-	1.74	2.16	95.92
Others	0.09	0.23	2.6	0.31	0.33	-	0.13	1.29
Total	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100

If it is assumed that all the Buddhists are Sinhalese, all Hindus are Tamils and all Muslims are Moors and Malays, then as can be seen from Table 6.6, in 1971, 93.5 percent of the Sinhalese were Buddhists and 86 percent of the Tamils were Hindus. Apart from this it is also evident that almost all the Moors and Malays were Muslims. At the same time it is justifiably assumed that almost all the non-Buddhist Sinhalese, non-Hindu Tamils and all the Burghers were Christians. "Religion has thus become closely associated with race and both are integrated together into the cultural values of the people. In consequence, the rise of nationalism has also seen the rise of religious consciousness."⁶

The numerical and percent distribution of the population of Sri Lanka by religion is shown in Table 6.8 below :-

TABLE 6.8 : NUMBER AND PERCENTAGE OF TOTAL POPULATION OF EACH RELIGION - 1971.

Denomination	Number in thousands	Percentage
All Religions	12,689.9	100
1. Buddhists	8,536.9	67.3
2. Hindus	2,238.7	17.6
3. Muslims	901.8	7.1
4. Roman Catholics	899.0	7.1
5. Other Christians	105.3	0.8
6. Others	8.3	0.1

5 N.K. Sarkar : "The Demography of Ceylon" - Page 203 Table 14.

6 N.K. Sarkar : "The Demography of Ceylon" - Page 203